

BUILDING UP AI

► **WITH THE LAUNCH OF SARVAM AI'S HOMEGROWN FOUNDATION MODELS—SARVAM-30B AND SARVAM-105B—INDIA HAS TAKEN AN IMPORTANT STEP TOWARDS TECHNOLOGICAL INDEPENDENCE**

► **SARVAM'S MODELS ARE BUILT SPECIFICALLY FOR INDIA'S REALITIES—22+ INDIAN LANGUAGES, VOICE-FIRST INTERFACES, AND VERNACULAR USE CASES. THIS MAKES THEM FAR MORE SUITED FOR BHARAT-SCALE DEPLOYMENT COMPARED WITH GLOBAL MODELS THAT ARE DESIGNED PRIMARILY FOR ENGLISH-DOMINANT MARKETS**

► **SARVAM OPERATED WITH FAR FEWER GPUS AND CAPITAL THAN GLOBAL LEADERS SUCH AS OPENAI. IT TRAINED COMPETITIVE MODELS USING ABOUT 4,096 GPUS AND A SMALL CORE TEAM. THIS DEMONSTRATES THAT FRONTIER AI DEVELOPMENT IS BECOMING MORE ACCESSIBLE AS COSTS DECLINE**

► **TRUE AI SOVEREIGNTY DEPENDS ON ENERGY INFRASTRUCTURE, CHIPS, COMPUTE EFFICIENCY, PLATFORMS, AND APPLICATIONS. WHILE INDIA HAS BEGUN BUILDING MODELS, THERE ARE GAPS IN HARDWARE, INFRASTRUCTURE, FUNDING, AND ENTERPRISE ADOPTION**

PHOTOS BY HARDIK CHHABRA



The Sarvam pavilion at the recent AI Summit in New Delhi

Hindi

less energy will matter. But overall, significant energy infrastructure will be needed.”

The next layer is semiconductor chips. “We are not in that race today. We will have to import. Over the long term, may be five years, that could change. After that comes the question of how efficiently you run these imported systems at scale. That’s another gap in India today. Then come the models. We are playing in that layer. But ultimately, the models have to be orchestrated into platforms, and platforms into vertical applications. Sovereignty has to be built across all these layers.”

INDIA'S TEST CASE

Founded in 2023 by Vivek Raghavan and Pratyush Kumar, also the CEO, Sarvam AI has emerged as one of the most closely watched players in India’s sovereign AI push. The Bengaluru-based start-up has raised \$54 million, including from Khosla Ventures and Lightspeed Venture Partners. It was also the first start-up to receive support under the IndiaAI Mission, the government’s ₹10,370 crore programme aimed at building indigenous AI capabilities.

Both the founders have deep experience of building technology at national scale. Kumar, an adjunct faculty member at the Indian Institute of Technology, Madras, had earlier co-founded AI4Bharat, an open-source initiative focused on advancing AI for Indian languages. Raghavan played a key role in scaling Aadhaar at the Unique Identification Authority of India, where he served as Chief Product Manager and Biometric Architect.

The founders told *BT* at the AI summit that their ambition goes beyond building a competitive model. The larger goal, they said, is to make AI accessible at population scale, drawing inspiration from digital public infrastructure playbooks of Aadhaar and UPI. This shapes how the company measures progress. Despite rapid ad-